Geographical Society – was more concerned with Hellenistic precedents than with present-day politics.

Like many others who would play the Great Game after him, it was Burnes's quick intelligence and skill in languages that got him his swift promotion, and despite coming from a relatively modest background in a relatively remote part of Scotland, he rose faster in the ranks than any of his richer and better-connected contemporaries. He was also assisted by the recommendations of his talented brother James and the connections both brothers made through their prominence in the Freemasons.[j]

An angular, wiry and witty man of five foot nine, 'spare and thin', Burnes was ambitious and determined, and had a cool head in an emergency. His friends admired his imagination and his intellectual agility: one wrote that he was 'sharp, quick and rapidly decisive, expressive and penetrating'. On this journey, he had ample opportunity to deploy both his intelligence and his wit, not least when he crossed the frontier to the Punjab and his lumbering carthorses caused a sensation among Ranjit Singh's officials. 'For the first time,' wrote Burnes, 'a dray horse was expected to gallop, canter and perform all the evolutions of the most agile animal.'

Burnes and his presents were received in great state in Lahore on 18 July 1831. A guard of cavalry and a regiment of infantry were sent to meet them. 'The coach, which was a handsome vehicle, headed the procession,' he recorded, 'and in the rear of the dray horses we ourselves followed on elephants, with the officers of the maharajah. We passed close under the city walls and entered Lahore by the palace gate. The streets were lined with cavalry, artillery and infantry, all of which saluted as we passed. The concourse of people was immense; they had seated themselves on the balconies of houses, and preserved a most respectful silence.' The British party was led across the outer courtyard of the old Mughal fort, and into the entrance of the arcaded marble reception room, the Diwan-i-Khas. 'Whilst stooping to remove my shoes,' Burnes wrote, 'I suddenly found myself in the arms and tight embrace of a diminutive, old-looking man.'[64]

This was Ranjit Singh, the Lion of the Punjab himself. Leading Burnes by the hand, he brought him into the court where 'all of us were seated on silver chairs, in front of his Highness'. It was now more than thirty years since Ranjit Singh had come to power, assisting Shah Zaman to save his cannon from the mud of the Jhelum, and thirteen years since Shah Shuja had fled Ranjit's enforced hospitality through the city sewers. Since then,